Having been beaten in Jaffna, the LTTE fled southwards to the safety of the jungles. Embroiled in counter-insurgency tasks, the IPKF had to be reinforced. In addition to 36 and 54 Infantry divisions, 4 Infantry and 57 Mountain divisions with one armoured regiment and two mechanized-infantry battalions were deployed. Lack of orientation of troops, tactical lapses and popular support for the LTTE made it difficult for the IPKF to operate effectively and casualties continued to mount.

In 1989, with normalcy having been more or less achieved, the hawkish Ranasinghe Premadasa won Sri Lanka’s presidential elections and demanded the IPKF’s withdrawal. India’s new government decided to withdraw the IPKF in a phased manner by March 1990. Often called India’s Vietnam, the 967-day misadventure had cost the Indian Army 1,200 lives and 4,500 wounded.